claim justice, allied to the houses of Timur and Sur – with Central Asians and Afghans – would the history of Hindustan itself have taken a new course?

Bairam's story never charted such tempting terrain; it reached an abrupt end instead. He stopped for a few days in Patan, then the capital of Gujarat. He went boating with his family; when they came ashore, a crowd of men were waiting for them, as if to pay their respects. Suspecting nothing, Bairam signalled for them to approach. It was a large group and Bairam was soon surrounded. Still, he suspected nothing. As Bairam talked and listened, one of the men standing behind him took out a dagger and stabbed him in the back, 'with such force that the point came out at his breast'.[109]

The assassin was an Afghan seeking vengeance for his father, killed in one of those early battles in Punjab that cleared Humayun's way to Delhi. Whether he wanted to or not, Khan Baba died in service of Babur's dynasty, his own future trickling to the dust like the blood from his chest.

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Back in Akbar's court, the wheels of government continued to turn. Munim Khan had made his way to Hindustan from Kabul, and been given Bairam Khan's position and title – that is, he was made Akbar's deputy, or vakil, and titled khan-khanan, the khan of khans. He was not, however, the former regent's sole replacement. Indeed, it speaks for the extent of Bairam's influence that his powers spilt across two, if not three, factions. On par with Munim Khan, if not a bit above him, was Maham Anaka, who 'took charge of affairs',[110] assisted by Shihabuddin, the friend whom Abul Fazl describes as one of Maham's 'tools'.

In clear opposition to this group was Akbar's ataka, Shamsuddin. It was Shamsuddin who had defeated Bairam on the rice fields of Punjab, and been rewarded with Bairam's standard, banner and drum, his fur robe and the 'choicest parts of the Punjab',[111] and titled Azam Khan – the greatest khan. This was not nearly enough for the ataka, however. Abul Fazl records – without comment – a letter that Shamsuddin wrote to Akbar soon after his victory over Bairam. Though couched in deference – 'prayers and expressions of devotion' – Shamsuddin's message was aggressive and clear. The recent battle had not been against Bairam alone, but also against the